

Lappy look out...



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I get emailed every single day by readers asking for advice on all kinds of gadgets. Sometimes, their requirements aren't clear and they just have a budget in mind. Lamington isn't the best place for laptops, so you're better off dropping into your local technology store at a mall. I decided to go down to some malls and also visit some sites as well, to look at what people were buying. With so many product releases, I wanted to refresh my own database of models and prices.

As expected, there were salesmen swarming me from the moment I started looking at some of the Sony models, with each of them asking me what I wanted. I told them I was just looking and continued my usual stroll. Students seemed to be getting interested in laptops in the ₹30,000 to ₹40,000 bracket. I noticed that there were some Sony EA and EB series models priced under ₹40,000. Sony is a brand best known for selling products priced over ₹45,000 – ₹50,000, so a product this cheap should be news to many. The entry-level models used Intel Core i3 350M processors with Intel integrated graphics. However, there are a few models priced at ₹3,000 – ₹4,000

more that includes an entry-level Radeon 5145 graphics solution that would be useful for HD content playback. Windows 7 Home edition is the operating system bundled with these laptops.

I found Dell too matches these Sony laptops with some models from their Inspiron series of laptops. I was on their site which allows you to customise some of the models. The most basic configuration on the 14-inch display was priced at ₹34,300 and if you opt out of the operating system, you can save around ₹1,500 less – great if you're using Linux. The configurations were similar to the ones by Sony. When I started looking at the larger Studio 15 range, I found that the configurations didn't change a lot except for the screen of course. The somewhat high-end model priced at ₹51,400 has a Core i5 processor, a 500GB drive and 4GB of RAM. I was pleased to see the very basic Vostro laptops from Dell as well. Prices start from only ₹28,000 and go up to around ₹35,000 depending on the configuration.

Acer also had a few models in this range. Acer has been considered a brand to look out for while searching for a budget laptop. The Aspire 4735z in particular is one of the cheapest value laptops around. With a Dual Core



For products such as laptops, street shopping isn't the best way and so I decided to explore the options we have...

Intel processor running at 2.2GHz, 3GB of RAM, and a 320GB hard drive, it's perfect for any student looking for a laptop to carry along for college.

There were also those who wanted a portable computing device instead of building an assembled PC for a little more than ₹20,000. Laptops priced at ₹35,000 were out of the question although that's what I normally recommend. The Compaq CQ-139TU was one model priced at just ₹24,400. While the old Dual Core 2.3GHz isn't going to match the performance of the Dell Studios or any of the Macs, it's one of those complete laptops with a DVD drive, a decent sized screen and something that will fulfil all of your office applications and internet browsing needs.

For absolute lifestyle products, it was back to brands such as Apple and Sony. Apple's Macbooks have been updated to the new Intel Core i5s and i7s. One of the cheapest models is priced at around ₹1,05,000. It comes with a 2.4GHz processor, 4GB RAM, 320GB HDD and a Radeon GT330M. Similarly, the Sony VPCF127HG from the F series of VAIO netbooks was also available I was told. The price tag was a ridiculous ₹1,29,900 for a Core i7 740QM, and a great 16.4-inch full HD display. The same GeForce GT330M GPU found on the Macbook was to be found in this as well. Yet another new model was the Sony Z series VPCZ128GG priced ₹1,59,900. With a small 13.1-inch HD1080 display, it runs one of the fastest mobile Core i7 processors. While the salesman went on forever about the product, it was pretty obvious that the price was for the two SSDs in RAID configuration. If you're looking for an over-the-top performing stylish netbook, then this should be it. 